

ECCLESIA DISCIPLESHIP & COMMISSIONING

EDC 110: DEALING WITH THE FLESH, EGO, AND AMBITION

Introduction

Many believers are trained to watch for Satan, persecution, false doctrine, and worldly systems. Yet Scripture consistently identifies a closer, more persistent adversary: **the uncrucified self**. The flesh, ego, and ambition do not announce themselves as enemies; they often appear as zeal, gifting, confidence, and spiritual hunger.

This course exists because spiritual failure rarely begins with doctrinal error. It begins with **inner disorder**: desires left unchecked, identity subtly shifted, and ambition slowly baptized with religious language.

The goal here is not self-hatred, but **spiritual clarity**.

Understanding the Flesh Biblically

In Scripture, “the flesh” does not simply refer to the physical body. Paul uses the term to describe the **fallen human nature operating independently of God**. The flesh is the inward system that seeks life, meaning, and fulfillment apart from the Spirit.

Galatians 5 presents the flesh and the Spirit not as mild tensions but as opposing powers. “*The flesh lusteth against the Spirit, and the Spirit against the flesh*” (Galatians 5:17). This conflict does not disappear at conversion; it is exposed by conversion.

The flesh is not improved by religious activity. It must be **put to death**.

One of the most dangerous misunderstandings in Christian formation is assuming that spiritual language equals spiritual life. Spiritual language pertains to the articulation of religious truth, but spiritual life consists in the inward transformation and participation in that truth; Scripture consistently warns that the former can exist without the latter, as the flesh is capable of mimicking the vocabulary of the Spirit without submitting to its power.

At the heart of this statement is the biblical distinction between **confession and condition**, between **verbal alignment with truth** and **existential participation in that truth**. Scripture does not assume that the use of spiritual vocabulary indicates the presence of spiritual reality. Rather, it repeatedly exposes the possibility that language can be orthodox while life remains untransformed.

In 2 Timothy 3:5, Paul warns of those “*having a form of godliness, but denying the power thereof*.” The word *form* (Greek: *morphōsis*) suggests an outward structure or appearance that resembles true godliness. This indicates that religious expression, including language, can mimic authentic spirituality without embodying its power.

The denial of power here is not necessarily verbal rejection, but practical absence: life that does not correspond to the claims being made.

Similarly, Titus 1:16 states, “*They profess that they know God; but in works they deny him.*” The term *profess* implies verbal declaration, yet this is contradicted by conduct. This establishes a critical exegetical principle: **in Scripture, true knowledge of God is verified by transformed living, not articulated language.** Knowledge (*gnōsis*) in the biblical sense is relational and participatory, not merely intellectual or linguistic.

Jesus intensifies this in Matthew 7:21–23, where individuals use explicitly spiritual language: “*Lord, Lord,*” and even recount prophetic and miraculous activities yet are rejected. This passage is particularly striking because it shows that even *charismatic expression* and *ministerial vocabulary* are not sufficient evidence of spiritual life. The issue is not what they said or did externally, but the absence of genuine relationship: “*I never knew you.*”

Theologically, this reveals that **spiritual language belongs to the realm of expression, but spiritual life belongs to the realm of ontology:** what one has become in Christ. Language can be learned, imitated, and performed within a community, but spiritual life is the product of regeneration (John 3:6), where “*that which is born of the Spirit is spirit.*” Without this new birth, even the most refined theological speech remains rooted in the flesh.

Paul further contrasts this in 1 Corinthians 4:20: “For the kingdom of God is not in word, but in power.” Here, “word” (*logos*) represents speech, rhetoric, or doctrinal articulation, while “power” (*dynamis*) refers to the active, transformative operation of God’s Spirit. The kingdom is therefore not authenticated by how well it is spoken, but by how truly it is manifested.

This is why the flesh can “*operate comfortably within religious structures.*” The flesh is not merely sinful behavior; it is the unregenerate human nature that can adapt to religious environments without surrendering to spiritual transformation. It can adopt the language of Zion while remaining unchanged in nature. This is seen in the Pharisaic tradition, where external conformity masked internal disconnection (cf. Matthew 23:27).

Paul confronts this in Philippians 3, where he lists his religious credentials only to declare them loss. His flesh was not immoral; it was **self-righteous**. Flesh does not always manifest as rebellion; often it manifests as self-trust.

This is why Jesus clashed most fiercely not with sinners, but with religious leaders.

Ego: The Desire to Be Central

Ego is the inward demand to matter, to be seen, to be affirmed, and to be significant. While the need for identity is God-given, ego corrupts that need by relocating identity from **sonship** to **self-performance**.

Ego may be understood as the inward drive for recognition, significance, and validation, which Scripture describes as the pursuit of “*honour... one of another*”

rather than that which comes from God alone (John 5:44). While the need for identity is rooted in divine intention, being fulfilled in sonship (Gal. 4:6–7), ego distorts this by shifting identity toward self-performance and fleshly striving (Gal. 3:3).

This impulse is not always overt; it often disguises itself within religious expression. Jesus warns against acts of devotion done “*to be seen of men*” (Matt. 6:1), revealing that even humility, service, and sacrifice can be subtly governed by the desire for visibility. Thus, ego is present wherever the heart seeks approval from men rather than God (Gal. 1:10).

The corrective is seen in the posture of John the Baptist, who, in the face of diminishing influence, declared, “*He must increase, but I must decrease*” (John 3:30). Here, true spirituality is defined not by self-preservation, but by the willing surrender of centrality, as identity rests securely in divine purpose rather than human recognition.

Ambition: When Desire Loses Alignment

Ambition, in itself, is not condemned in Scripture. Paul employs the language of holy aspiration, declaring his aim (*philotimeomai*) to preach Christ where He had not been named (Rom. 15:20; cf. 2 Cor. 5:9). Thus, ambition becomes righteous when it is governed by divine purpose and aligned with God’s will.

The danger emerges in misaligned ambition—when the pursuit of calling is subtly replaced by the pursuit of visibility, and purpose gives way to platform. Jesus exposes this distortion in His disciples, contrasting worldly ambition for status with kingdom greatness defined by servanthood (Mark 10:42–45).

Scripture further identifies fleshly ambition as that which is driven by *eritheia* (self-seeking striving) and *kenodoxia* (vain glory), where actions are motivated by recognition rather than obedience (Phil. 2:3; Gal. 5:26). In this sense, ambition becomes corrupt when the heart is more invested in outcomes than faithfulness, and in being seen rather than being sent.

James warns that such ambition produces “confusion and every evil work” (James 3:16), revealing that its fruit is disorder rather than righteousness. Though spiritual ambition may appear noble in language, it is exposed through its symptoms—comparison (2 Cor. 10:12), impatience with divine timing (Heb. 6:12), and subtle frustration with God’s process.

The Flesh and the Desire for Control

The flesh, as presented in Scripture, is not merely human weakness but human nature operating in resistance to God. Paul describes the carnal mind as “not subject to the law of God” (Rom. 8:7), revealing that at its core, the flesh resists surrender and thus resists trust. Trust requires yielding control, but the flesh is oriented toward self-direction rather than dependence on the Spirit (Gal. 5:17).

This resistance expresses itself as a desire for control—over timing, process, relationships, and outcomes. To “make flesh one’s arm” is to rely on human strength

and understanding (Jer. 17:5), in contrast to the call to trust the Lord fully and relinquish self-reliance (Prov. 3:5–6).

For this reason, surrender feels threatening to the uncrucified self. Jesus calls His disciples to deny themselves and take up the cross (Luke 9:23), while Paul affirms that those who belong to Christ have crucified the flesh (Gal. 5:24). The flesh resists because surrender is not modification but death to self-rule.

This dynamic is illustrated in Peter's rebuke of Jesus (Matt. 16:22–23). Though his words appeared protective, Jesus identified them as adversarial because they opposed the divine necessity of the cross. Peter's mindset reflected human reasoning rather than divine purpose. Thus, the flesh consistently argues for preservation over obedience, seeking to secure life on its own terms rather than lose it in submission to God (Matt. 16:25).

Crucifixion, Not Management

Scripture never instructs believers to manage the flesh, negotiate with ego, or redirect ambition. It calls for crucifixion. "They that are Christ's have crucified the flesh with the affections and lusts" (Galatians 5:24).

Crucifixion is decisive, painful, and irreversible. It does not happen through self-effort but through cooperation with the Spirit. The cross is not merely historical; it is personal.

Daily discipleship involves choosing death to self-rule so that Christ's life may be expressed.

7. How the Spirit Exposes the Flesh

The Holy Spirit exposes the flesh not through condemnation, but through light. Jesus declares that the Spirit will "*reprove*" (elenchō) the world (John 16:8), a term that denotes conviction by unveiling truth. In this way, what is hidden is brought into visibility, for "*all things that are reproved are made manifest by the light*" (Eph. 5:13). This work differs fundamentally from condemnation, for "*there is therefore now no condemnation to them which are in Christ Jesus*" (Rom. 8:1). Conviction restores by revealing; condemnation distances by accusing.

Through this revelatory work, the Spirit identifies what resists God within the believer. By the application of truth, the inner life is discerned: "*the thoughts and intents of the heart*" (Heb. 4:12) so that what is misaligned may be surrendered and brought into sanctification (John 17:17).

This exposure often occurs within the processes God ordains: through correction, testing, delay, and circumstantial pressure. The Lord chastens those He loves (Heb. 12:6), and through seasons of testing reveals what is within the heart (Deut. 8:2), not merely to inform, but to transform.

Yet many misinterpret this work, resisting conviction as though it were spiritual attack. Scripture warns against despising or fainting under the Lord's rebuke (Heb.

12:5). In contrast, maturity is marked by a yielded posture that welcomes divine searching: “*Search me, O God... and see if there be any wicked way in me*” (Ps. 139:23–24). Thus, the evidence of growth is not the absence of exposure, but the willingness to lean into it, recognizing conviction as the Spirit’s commitment to the believer’s formation.

Community and Accountability as Mirrors

The flesh thrives in isolation. Ego grows where there is no correction. Ambition distorts when there is no submission. God therefore places believers in community not merely for fellowship, but for **mutual formation**.

Scripture affirms that wounds from faithful friends are a means of grace. Community reveals blind spots that private spirituality cannot address.

The Flesh in Ministry Contexts

Ministry, in itself, does not eliminate the flesh; it can instead amplify it. Scripture demonstrates that spiritual activity is not equivalent to spiritual maturity. Jesus warns that many will prophesy, cast out demons, and perform works in His name, yet remain unknown to Him (Matt. 7:22–23). Likewise, Paul affirms that one may operate in extraordinary gifts and yet lack the essential substance of love (1 Cor. 13:1–3). Thus, giftedness can function alongside an unformed inner life.

For this reason, giftedness without inward governance often results in spiritual harm. Paul himself disciplines his body lest, after preaching to others, he be disqualified (1 Cor. 9:27), and James cautions that those who teach are held to stricter judgment (James 3:1). Influence does not sanctify the flesh; it magnifies its effects when left unchecked.

Consequently, many public failures are the outward manifestation of privately tolerated desires. Scripture traces sin from inward lust to outward action (James 1:14–15), revealing that what is indulged in secret eventually becomes visible in conduct.

This is why the apostolic writings prioritize character over charisma. The qualifications for leadership emphasize integrity, self-control, and spiritual maturity (1 Tim. 3:2–7; Titus 1:7–9), rather than gifting or platform. Anointing, when not accompanied by formation, becomes unstable and potentially destructive.

Freedom from the flesh, however, is not achieved through repression, but through surrender. The call is not merely to restrain the flesh, but to walk in the Spirit (Gal. 5:16) and to present oneself wholly to God (Rom. 12:1). As identity becomes anchored in Christ “your life is hid with Christ in God” (Col. 3:3) ego is deprived of its fuel. As trust replaces self-reliance, ambition is realigned. And as the Spirit governs, the deeds of the flesh are put to death (Rom. 8:13).

True freedom is not the absence of desire but the **ordering of desire under God**.

Conclusion

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Dealing with the flesh, ego, and ambition is not a phase of early discipleship; it is a lifelong discipline. Yet the goal is not constant introspection, but increasing liberty. As self-rule diminishes, Christ's life flows more freely.

This course prepares disciples not just to begin well, but to **end well**: rooted, sober, and faithful.

Signed:

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